

Retrofitting a commercial RF induction generator into a computer-controlled, vacuum-integrated annealing system for reactive-metal grain growth

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High-temperature vacuum annealing near a metal’s melting point drives controlled grain growth, but it normally requires an expensive turn-key vacuum induction furnace. We describe an open modernization stack that converts a bare commercial RF induction generator into a computer-controlled, vacuum-integrated annealing system with pyrometer feedback. The stack consists of LabVIEW/DAQ analog power control, dual-wavelength optical temperature feedback, a high-vacuum quartz-tube chamber, and an in-house machined graphite crucible that serves as a susceptor for metal specimens. The stack transfers between generators because its only requirement is a monotonic analog power-control input. The reproducible build is anchored on a current 6 kW solid-state generator. In operation, the system produced a fixed-geometry power–temperature calibration with $R^2 = 0.991$ over 1200–1400 °C. Eight nickel anneals at 1200 °C for 12 h reproduced their soak temperature to 1201.2 ± 1.3 °C, and soaks up to 40 h at 1325 °C remained stable. The annealed nickel microstructures were characterized by optical metallography, SEM, and EBSD. A tantalum-susceptor variant extends the furnace to non-coupling ceramics at 2000–2350 °C, demonstrated with YSZ grain growth. Complete design files, the bill of materials, the control software, and the data are openly available.

Keywords: induction furnace; grain growth; vacuum annealing; LabVIEW; pyrometer; open-source hardware

I. INTRODUCTION

High-temperature annealing near a metal’s melting point drives controlled grain growth. This is central to studying microstructure–property relationships in metals such as nickel and iron^{1–5}. Growing grains without oxidizing the sample requires temperatures of 1400 to 1500 °C along with high vacuum or an inert atmosphere^{6,7}. Commercial vacuum induction furnaces that meet these requirements are closed, turn-key systems costing \$50k to \$200k or more. Resistive tube and box furnaces reach lower temperatures with slower ramps, and they offer no susceptor route to charges that do not couple to the RF field. Bare industrial induction generators are widely available, but they ship without vacuum, optical temperature feedback, or computer setpoint control.

This work adds that missing layer. A bare RF induction generator^{8,9} is retrofitted into a full annealing system with computer power control, closed-loop optical temperature feedback, a high-vacuum quartz-tube chamber, and a machined graphite crucible that doubles as a susceptor. The stack is deliberately generator-agnostic. Its only requirement is an analog power-control input, such as 4–20 mA or 0–5 V, with a monotonic command-to-power response. The pyrometer feedback and PID calibration absorb any nonlinearity in that response. The generator internals are not reproduced, so a compatible generator needs to be supplied. The graphite crucible couples strongly to the RF field and serves the metal grain-growth charges. Non-coupling ceramics such as YSZ use an entirely separate tantalum-susceptor charge stack (Sec. V A).

The reproducible build documented here is anchored

on a current, USA-sourced 6 kW solid-state generator whose controller accepts a standard 4–20 mA power setpoint. The package of generator, heating head, controller, and chiller was quoted at approximately \$16.5k. The retrofit components are itemized in the supplementary bill of materials. This is a small fraction of turn-key cost, in a form the user can repair and modify.

II. SYSTEM DESIGN AND DESCRIPTION

The system comprises five subsystems (Fig. 1). Figure 2 shows the assembled system at operating power.

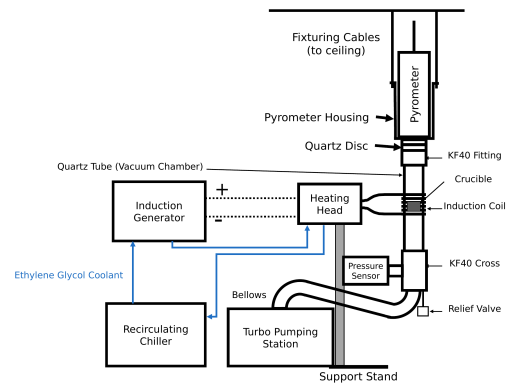


FIG. 1. System overview. The generator drives the liquid-cooled heating head and work coil around the vertically suspended quartz-tube chamber. The chamber stack is joined by KF40 flanges to the ceiling-suspended pyrometer housing. An overpressure relief valve and a flexible bellows lead past the pressure sensor to the turbo pumping station.

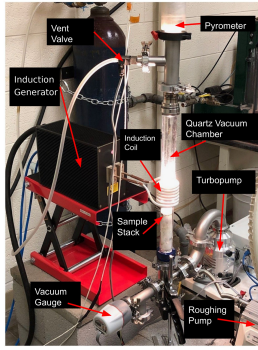


FIG. 2. The assembled, functioning furnace with the main components labeled. The quartz chamber glows at the sample-stack position. The pyrometer sights down the chamber axis, and the vent valve admits the argon backfill. The gauge, turbopump, and separately supported roughing pump complete the vacuum path.

The heating subsystem is a 6 kW solid-state induction generator driving a liquid-cooled copper work coil. The coil is approximately 3 in tall and 2.5 in in inner diameter, with 6.5 turns tuned to the sample and crucible stack^{10,11}. The coil conductors carry both the RF current and the coolant. Ethylene glycol coolant flows in series from the chiller through the generator and then through the heating head and work coil before returning to the chiller. The vacuum and gas subsystem starts from the 35 mm inner-diameter fused-quartz tube that forms the chamber. The tube connects through a KF40 flange and a flexible bellows to a compact turbo pumping station that reaches 10^{-6} to 10^{-8} Torr. A manual vent valve fed from an inert-gas regulator allows controlled venting and backfilling^{12,13}. The atmosphere matters for graphite-crucible anneals. The best results were achieved by pumping to high vacuum and then backfilling with argon through the vent valve, purging first and then settling to a steady trickle of approximately 20 SCCM. Heating under vacuum alone tended to sublime graphite onto the chamber walls. For the highest-temperature ceramic work (Sec. V A), the chamber was evacuated and then continuously filled with argon while the turbopump was running. This helped avoid oxidation during heating.

Temperature is sensed optically. A dual-wavelength ratio pyrometer^{14,15} with an 800 to 2500 °C sensing range views the sample through a KF40 optical window. This provides a non-contact signal that is robust to emissivity changes and to the RF field that would corrupt thermocouples^{16–18}. Control is implemented in LabVIEW, with VIs for manual control, automated ramping, PID tuning, and email alerts. The DAQ’s 0–5 V analog output drives a voltage-to-current loop conditioner, and the conditioner’s 4–20 mA output lands on the generator’s power-setpoint input. The pyrometer’s analog output returns to a DAQ input, which closes the PID loop. Below the pyrometer’s detection floor of approximately 700 °C, the VI ramps open-loop. Once the pyrometer returns

a sustained valid reading, control hands over to closed-loop PID on the optical temperature^{19,20}. Mechanically, a bolted support stand carries the generator’s heating head and centers the work coil on the crucible position. The vacuum chamber itself has no support stand. The chamber stack is joined by KF40 flanges to the pyrometer housing, which is suspended from the ceiling by cables, so the vertical stack hangs from above.

Metal charges in the graphite crucible reach the nickel and iron grain-growth range of 1400 to 1500 °C, with demonstrated soaks from minutes to 40 h. The separate tantalum-susceptor ceramic configuration extends the working range to 2000 to 2350 °C. The layer transfers to any generator that exposes a monotonic analog power input, supports a liquid-cooled head and coil of the documented geometry, delivers enough RF power for the target charge, and allows electrical isolation of the DAQ and control path. When porting, the command scaling, calibration, PID gains, alignment, and interlock behavior are re-established.

A. Graphite crucible / susceptor

Metal specimens are held in a two-piece graphite crucible machined in-house from 3000 °C-grade graphite stock. It consists of a cup body and a lidded cap with a central bore, which contains the charge while leaving an optical path for the pyrometer. The graphite couples strongly to the induction field and acts as a susceptor, heating the contained metal specimen by conduction and radiation. The specimen is sandwiched between two alumina discs in the cup, the lid seats on top, and a sapphire window closes the lid bore (Fig. 3). Sapphire is used for the window to increase transmittance in the wavelength ranges emitted from the sample relative to the pyrometry. When fully assembled the stack stands 13 mm tall, and the measured dimensions of every piece are given in the supplementary material. Inside the vacuum chamber the crucible rests on an alumina support rod that positions it at coil height. Crucibles are repaired with graphite cement rather than discarded. The graphite crucible is used exclusively for metal grain growth. Ceramic charges are never loaded into it. They instead use the entirely separate tantalum-susceptor stack of Sec. V A.

III. CONSTRUCTION AND OPERATION

Following the heating path, the generator’s heating head mounts on an adjustable platform on the bolted support stand so the coil centers on the crucible position of the vertically suspended quartz tube. The vacuum path begins at the quartz tube, whose open end terminates in a KF40 flange closed by a 55 mm quartz optical disc. Every flanged joint compresses an elastomer O-ring carried on a centering ring, so the stack assembles with hand-tightened clamps and no tools. These seals support

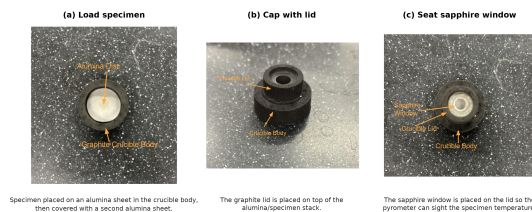


FIG. 3. Specimen-loading sequence for the graphite crucible/susceptor. (a) The specimen is placed between two alumina sheets in the crucible body. (b) The graphite lid is seated on top. (c) The sapphire window closes the lid bore, leaving an optical path for the pyrometer.

the 10^{-6} to 10^{-8} Torr operating vacuum. From the bottom of the stack, a tee carries a 0.5 psi overpressure relief valve that protects the quartz tube during backfilling. A flexible bellows continues through the wide-range vacuum gauge to the turbo pumping station. The roughing pump sits on a separate support, mechanically decoupled so its vibration does not reach the chamber or the pyrometer sight line. On the gas path, the argon regulator feeds the manual vent valve. A mass flow controller between them is helpful when continuous inert gas flow is required. On the control path, electrical isolation is maintained between the DAQ wiring and the generator interface. Manual control is verified before automated ramping and soaking are enabled.

A run begins with the chamber vented, which is done only after the turbo pump has stopped spinning. The specimen is loaded into the crucible (Fig. 3), the stack is inserted, and the chamber is pumped down. The LabVIEW profile ramps open-loop below the pyrometer floor, hands over to closed-loop PID, and runs the programmed soak. Afterwards the sample cools under vacuum, and the chamber is vented only once the turbo pump has stopped.

IV. PERFORMANCE VALIDATION

The furnace has completed more than one hundred logged anneals of Ni200 and Ni4N5 nickel, YSZ, and Pd thermal-evaporation charges at 900 to 1400 °C, with soaks from minutes to 40 h. The supplementary material links each result below to its underlying run log.

For one fixed configuration of Ni4N5 specimen, quartz tube, graphite crucible, and optics, four steady-state anneals spanning 1200 to 1400 °C give a monotonic relation between the soak-mean analog power command and the soak-mean pyrometer temperature. The relation is well described by $T = 931 + 632I$, with T in °C and I in mA, and $R^2 = 0.991$. The offset shifts with charge and optical configuration, so this is an operational calibration for a given setup, not a universal command-temperature law. A Ni4N5 anneal at a nominal 1300 °C and 12 h condition serves as the representative closed-loop run, and its trace is given in the supplementary material. The

soak held 1302.1 ± 3.0 °C over the 12 h plateau. The 10–90 % rise time was approximately 1135 s, the overshoot was approximately 12 °C, and the drift was a negligible -0.02 °C per hour.

Eight Ni4N5 anneals at a nominal 1200 °C and 12 h condition were run under the same gas-flow configuration. They reproduced their soak temperature to 1201.2 ± 1.3 °C, a coefficient of variation of 0.11 %. Long-duration stability was demonstrated with two Ni200 anneals at 1325 °C. The first held for 20 h at 1326.5 ± 1.5 °C with a drift of -0.004 °C per hour, and the second held for 40 h. Figures for both are in the supplementary material. Reported temperatures are closed-loop ratio-pyrometer readings in a fixed optical geometry. Absolute specimen temperature still depends on emissivity and surface condition^{16,21,22}.

V. MICROSTRUCTURAL VALIDATION

The furnace exists to change microstructure, so the decisive test is what the anneals do to real specimens. Figure 4 shows a raw electron-backscatter (Kikuchi) pattern from a furnace-annealed nickel specimen, reproduced exactly as the EBSD detector saved it during orientation mapping. Even at the coarse 8×8 binning used for mapping, the bands and zone axes are crisply resolved. Inverse-pole-figure maps built from such patterns resolve hundreds of indexed grains per specimen. Thermal grooving is itself a record of the anneal. Edge-on views of a specimen annealed at 1200 °C for 12 h, cleaned only ultrasonically, show deep grooves and boundaries that traverse the full sheet thickness. This is a step toward columnar grain structures²³.

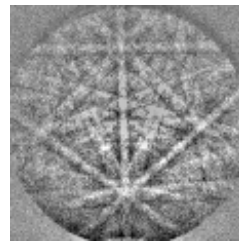


FIG. 4. Raw electron-backscatter (Kikuchi) pattern from a furnace-annealed nickel specimen, exactly as saved by the EBSD detector during orientation mapping (the detector's 8×8 -binned output). The crisply resolved bands and zone axes index directly to the nickel lattice.

Figure 5 shows the microstructure such an anneal produces for a Ni4N5 specimen soaked 20 h at 1300 °C under the argon trickle flow, with a measured soak of approximately 1301 °C. The optical grain map resolves an equiaxed grain network delineated by thermal grooving alone. Grain-size measurements were made directly in the image against its 200 μm scale bar. The SEM detail resolves an individual boundary groove at the micrometer scale²⁴.

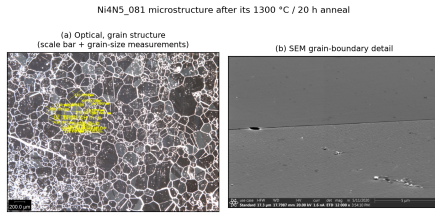


FIG. 5. Microstructure of a Ni4N5 specimen after a 1300 °C / 20 h anneal under argon trickle flow. (a) Optical grain map with in-image grain-size measurements (200 μm scale bar); (b) high-magnification SEM grain-boundary detail.

A. Extension to ceramic charges: YSZ

The same induction furnace can also be used to process refractory ceramics by modifying only the materials directly in contact with the specimen while leaving the generator, vacuum system, pyrometer, cooling system, and control software unchanged. Materials that do not couple directly to the RF field require a susceptor to absorb RF energy and transfer heat to the specimen. At the temperatures required for grains to coarsen on refractory ceramics, the primary consideration in selecting a susceptor is its chemical compatibility with the specimen and surrounding support materials rather than its RF heating performance. Graphite and tantalum both serve effectively as susceptors, with the preferred choice depending on the operating temperature and the materials in contact with the susceptor.

Grain growth in refractory ceramics follows Arrhenius kinetics and is therefore highly sensitive to annealing temperature. For the 8 mol% YSZ specimens investigated here, grain growth from approximately 10 μm to 90 μm required 228 h at 1600 °C in a conventional box furnace, whereas comparable grain growth was achieved in only 45 min at 2500 °C using the induction furnace (Fig. 6). Achieving these temperatures required only minor modifications to the charge stack. For example, direct contact between graphite and alumina was eliminated because they undergo a eutectic reaction that lowers the interface melting temperature to approximately 1800 °C. This was accomplished by introducing a boron nitride diffusion barrier between the two materials. Alternatively, replacing the graphite with tantalum avoids this compatibility issue while still providing efficient RF coupling.

VI. CONCLUSIONS

A bare commercial RF induction generator can be converted into a computer-controlled, vacuum-integrated, pyrometer-feedback annealing system with a documented, generator-agnostic modernization layer. On a current solid-state generator the stack demonstrated a power-temperature calibration with $R^2 = 0.991$, high

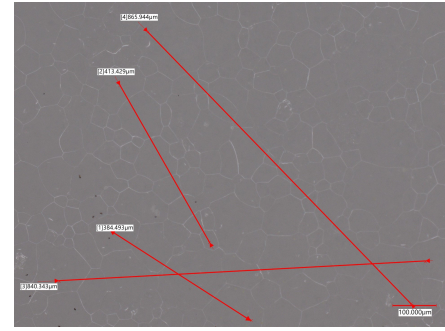


FIG. 6. As-recorded optical micrograph of the YSZ specimen after the 2500 °C / 45 min tantalum-susceptor anneal, which coarsened the grains from approximately 20 to 90 μm. The red multi-grain measurement traces and the 100 μm scale bar are part of the original microscope record.

soak repeatability, stable closed-loop soaks up to 40 h, and annealed nickel whose surfaces index directly in the EBSD and show controlled grain growth.

The tantalum-susceptor variant shows how far the same furnace stretches without redesign. Exchanging only the charge stack carries the system from metal anneals in the graphite crucible to ceramic grain growth beyond 2300 °C. The survey behind that result identified chemistry, not power, as the governing constraint at extreme temperature. Every failure mode was a contact reaction between the charge, the susceptor, and the crucible. The interchangeable stack lets a user iterate on those material choices run by run. Because the modernization layer requires only a monotonic analog power-control input, the design ports across generators and is directly reusable at a small fraction of turn-key cost. The through-thickness boundary grooving points to columnar grain-growth studies as a natural next application.

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AUTHOR DECLARATIONS

Conflict of Interest

The authors have no conflicts to disclose.

Ethics Approval

This work did not involve human or animal subjects; ethics approval is not applicable.

Author Contributions

— provisional: **Sterling G. Baird:** Conceptualization, Software, Investigation, Writing – original draft. **Ryan Weber:** Investigation, Methodology, Data curation, Visualization. **Christopher Nyborg:** Investigation, Methodology, Data curation, Visualization. **Ronnie Guymon:** Visualization, Writing – review & editing. **Gage Erickson:** Visualization, Writing – review & editing. **Oliver Johnson:** Supervision, Project administration.

DATA AVAILABILITY

The data that support the findings of this study are openly available in the development repository (<https://github.com/vertical-cloud-lab/custom-induction-furnace>); an archival snapshot is deposited at Zenodo, <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20878017>.

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